

PAST AND PRESENT
Artefacts on display at the Humayun's Tomb Museum

ART ▼

WHEN UTILITY MEETS BEAUTY

ART PATRON O.P. JAIN'S COLLECTION OF VINTAGE EVERYDAY OBJECTS AND TEXTILES FINDS A NEW HOME IN DELHI

A brass *lota*, a *gujiya* mould, an infant's walker or a back scratcher don't often find pride of place in a museum. Yet, at the newly inaugurated Sanskriti Museum of Indian Textiles and Everyday Art at the Humayun's Tomb World Heritage Site Museum in Delhi, they take centre stage, alongside 1,700 artefacts and 100 textiles collected by O.P. Jain, founder of the Sanskriti Foundation.

GATHERED ON TRIPS ACROSS INDIA IN THE 1970s, THESE ANTIQUE PIECES ENCOMPASS TOYS, STATIONERY, KITCHEN TOOLS AND RITUAL OBJECTS

Jain wasn't looking for rare antiquities in the late 1970s, travelling across India for his paper business, but ended up bringing back lamps, locks and textiles that reflected the craftsmanship of everyday India. The collection remained at Sanskriti Kendra in Anandgram before Jain gifted it to the Indira Gandhi National Centre for the Arts (IGNCA) in 2023, which has now placed it at the Tomb Museum.

"These are not ancient objects but lived art," says Archana Saad Akhtar, programme director (design), Aga Khan Trust for Culture, which has curated the display and will oversee the museum's day-to-day management along with its permanent exhibition. "Many of these crafts, motifs and techniques have already disappeared."

The galleries adopt a life-cycle approach, bringing together *kalamdaans*, ceremonial toys, kitchen tools, hookahs, *lotas*, prayer and ritual objects. Motifs of peacocks, horses, mythology and tiny *ghunghroos* show how artistry was woven into everyday objects.

The adjoining textile section features Dhakai *jamdanis*, Sindh embroideries, Varanasi brocades, *pichwais*, Kani shawls and Jain temple hangings from Rajasthan and Gujarat. ■

—Geetika Sachdev

Museum is open 10 am-6 pm on all days except Mondays. Entry fee: Rs 50, with 50 visitors permitted per hour



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Converging in the Present

True to name, the third edition of *Contemporary Now–Edition III* showcases leading Indian artists and galleries in a shared presentation of contemporary art

For a country of 121 languages (or 380 if one considers languages no longer in use), what is but a word? Spread out across nine galleries through Belvedere House of the National Library in Kolkata, the Museum of Word explores India's linguistic heritage right from the very first observed sym-

THE STUFF OF SPEECH
Below, visitors at the Museum of Word; right, 8th century copper inscription



Photographs by DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY